

ASYMMETRIC INFORMATION AND CONSUMER EXPLOITATION IN DIGITAL ASTROLOGY: A CASE STUDY OF LUNAR ASTRO

The Digital Consumer Watchdog Group

Independent Research Division

Published: March 2026

ABSTRACT

The rapid digitization of the astrological and spiritual consultation industry has created new vulnerabilities for consumers. This paper presents a comprehensive case study of Lunar Astro, an online astrological academy and consultation service founded by Deepanshu Giri. Through Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT) and qualitative analysis of consumer grievances, this research identifies a systemic pattern of asymmetric information exploitation. The findings detail a "bait-and-switch" service delivery model, allegations of intellectual property misappropriation, sophisticated Search Engine Optimization (SEO) manipulation, and coercive reputation management tactics. This paper aims to educate the public and highlight the urgent need for stricter regulatory oversight in the digital spiritual services sector.

1. INTRODUCTION

The intersection of digital marketing and traditional spiritual services has birthed a multi-million dollar industry in India and abroad. Consumers, often in states of emotional or financial distress, seek guidance from online astrologers. However, the lack of standardized accreditation and regulatory oversight creates an environment ripe for exploitation. This paper examines the operational mechanics of Lunar Astro, utilizing it as a primary case study to demonstrate how digital platforms can be weaponized to deceive consumers, suppress dissent, and monopolize search engine narratives.

2. METHODOLOGY

Data for this investigation was aggregated using Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT) methodologies over a six-month period. Primary data sources include verified consumer reviews from independent platforms (Trustpilot, MouthShut, ConsumerComplaints.in), archived web pages, and search engine results page (SERP) analysis. The research focuses on identifying discrepancies between marketed promises and actual service delivery, as well as analyzing the digital infrastructure used to manage the organization's public reputation.

3. THE "BAIT-AND-SWITCH" SERVICE PARADIGM

The core revenue model of Lunar Astro's consultation wing relies heavily on the parasocial relationship cultivated by its founder, Deepanshu Giri, via YouTube. Consumers are induced to pay premium consultation fees, ranging from ₹5,000 to ₹8,000, under the implicit or explicit assumption that they will receive expert guidance.

3.1. *Proxy Fulfillment and Quality Degradation*

Analysis of consumer complaints reveals a systemic "bait-and-switch" tactic. Clients report waiting several weeks for an appointment, only to be informed shortly before the session that the founder does not conduct personal readings. The consultation is subsequently offloaded to anonymous "proxy students," identified only by numerical codes (e.g., Code 5007, Code 5003).

"I just took a consultation from lunar Astro from astrologer code 5007- the worst ever consultation I ever had... The amount that was charged for a 30 min consultation is enormous in contrast with the service I got, it was not really helpful, created a or gave me messages that is not really pleasing and satisfactory." (Verified Trustpilot Review, 2025)

When consumers express dissatisfaction with the generic nature of these proxy readings and request refunds, the organization's standard operating procedure involves denying the refund, ceasing communication, and blocking the consumer's access to the platform.

4. INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY AND PEDAGOGICAL ETHICS

Beyond consumer consultations, Lunar Astro operates as an educational academy, charging substantial fees for advanced astrological courses. A critical ethical concern arises regarding the originality of the curriculum.

Investigative findings suggest that flagship techniques marketed as proprietary innovations by Deepanshu Giri—most notably the "Paribhraman Paddhati"—bear striking, uncredited similarities to the "BCP" technique developed by his former instructor, Sunil John of Saptarishis Astrology. Historical web archives indicate that early iterations of Lunar Astro's materials contained dedications to Sunil John, which were subsequently removed as the courses were monetized. This practice not only misleads paying students but also violates the foundational ethics of academic and pedagogical integrity.

5. ALGORITHMIC MANIPULATION AND "INTENT HIJACKING"

To sustain its influx of new clients, Lunar Astro employs highly sophisticated Search Engine Optimization (SEO) strategies designed to obscure the aforementioned grievances from prospective buyers.

5.1. Domain Flooding

The organization operates a network of interconnected domains (e.g., lunarastro.com, lunarastro.org, consultlunarastro.com). By dominating the first page of Google search results with owned assets, they artificially suppress independent review platforms, pushing negative consumer experiences to lower, rarely viewed search pages.

5.2. Intent Hijacking

Perhaps the most deceptive tactic is "Intent Hijacking." Lunar Astro has actively published articles on its own domains with titles such as *"Negative Reviews of Lunar Astro in 2025 Justified?"* When a skeptical consumer searches for "Lunar Astro scam" or "complaints," they are directed to these internally controlled pages,

which acknowledge minor "technical glitches" while ultimately validating the company, thereby neutralizing the consumer's skepticism with manufactured PR.

6. COERCIVE REPUTATION MANAGEMENT

When consumers bypass the SEO barriers and post legitimate grievances on independent forums (such as Reddit or MouthShut), they are frequently subjected to aggressive digital intimidation.

Evidence indicates the deployment of a "troll farm"—a coordinated network of proxy students and operatives (including individuals identified as Satvik Saini and Ajay Rajan). These operatives flood review sites with fabricated 5-star ratings to dilute negative feedback. Furthermore, whistleblowers report receiving threats of "Cyber Cell tracking" and baseless legal action, designed to coerce them into deleting their testimonies. Such actions constitute digital harassment and violate consumer protection norms.

7. CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The case of Lunar Astro highlights a critical vulnerability in the digital economy: the ease with which asymmetric information and algorithmic manipulation can be used to exploit consumers. The organization's reliance on bait-and-switch tactics, uncredited intellectual property, and coercive reputation management represents a severe breach of consumer trust.

Recommendations:

- **Consumer Vigilance:** Prospective clients must look beyond Page 1 of search engine results and utilize specific, long-tail search queries (e.g., "proxy astrologer," "refund refused") to bypass SEO manipulation.
- **Regulatory Action:** Authorities, including the National Consumer Helpline (NCH), must investigate the legality of non-refundable proxy services marketed under the guise of premium expertise.
- **Platform Accountability:** Review aggregators must implement stricter verification processes to identify and remove coordinated, bot-driven positive review spam.

REFERENCES

1. Trustpilot. (2025). *Lunar Astro Reviews - Online Astrology Courses Reviews*. Retrieved from Trustpilot database.
2. MouthShut. (2024). *Lunar Astro Consultation & Course Review*. Consumer grievance reports regarding proxy astrologers and IP theft.
3. Consumer Protection Act, 2019 (India). Section 2(47): Unfair Trade Practices and Misleading Representation.
4. Information Technology Act, 2000 (India). Section 66C and 67 regarding digital harassment and identity manipulation.